

EYEWITNESS October 1968–September 1969

Nursing the Seriously Wounded

Nurses, like combat soldiers, went to Vietnam with a resigned sense of service to their country. However, the reality of war was often shocking and permanently transforming. On returning to the US, Nancy Randolph, a nurse from the South who served in Vietnam for a year, found a medical culture and society from which she felt alienated.

“I must say that I believe there were more reasons than one for my decision to go to Vietnam ... When you are twenty-two, glory presents itself in various ways. To be a combat nurse brought all sorts of visions to mind ...

The saddest thing I'd ever encountered after I'd been there a while was to see the human body and what war does to it ... Once the doctor triaged them, if they were in the expectant category [expected to die] ... they were medicated and bathed if they were dirty ... They were cared for, but still, it was so sad just to put them behind a screen and check them every so often so you could get the time of death right ...

Back in the United States as a professional nurse has had its complications. The Vietnam nurses were good. You had to be good ... I came back to rural counties, and I ... have to ask permission to give an aspirin? Come on, give me a break ... Or I'd have to listen to some doc ... chew me out for whatever, after what I'd seen and done ... I just didn't need it ... [Vietnam] made me a better person. It showed me, up front, at the ripe old age of twenty-two, what I could do without and still survive—what was important and what wasn't.”

US ARMY NURSE NANCY RANDOLPH, INTERVIEWED IN *THE HUMAN TRADITION IN THE VIETNAM ERA* (SCHOLARLY RESOURCES, AN IMPRINT OF ROWMAN & LITTLEFIELD), 1998